

The vague prompt fail

```
> Write a script to clean up old files # generic answer with  
generic assumptions - Delete files older than 90 days -  
Assume C:\Temp - No dry-run - No logging - No safety  
guardrails
```

The model filled in the blanks. You just didn't know which blanks you left.

Context is king

Prompting is not magic phrasing. It is **deliberately feeding context**.

Thesis: The more context you feed, the less you have to explain later.

Why context matters

*I micromanage because I'm sculpting.
There's no way I could fully specify
something up front and expect AI to get
everything I was thinking implicitly.*

— Scott Hanselman · *Scott & Mark Learn To... Have Taste*

Vague prompt

More guessing. More correction. More wasted turns.

Context up front

Better first draft. Fewer surprises. Faster convergence.

The lever

Front-load the iteration. Be specific earlier so you spend less time correcting later.

The context layers

IMPACT	LAYER	WHAT IT GIVES THE MODEL	INFRA-FLAVORED EXAMPLE
1	Custom instructions	Global conventions, defaults, guardrails	<code>.github/copilot-instructions.md</code> with logging and error patterns
2	Workspace context	Repo-wide structure and adjacent files	<code>@workspace</code> over your IaC repo
3	Active file + selection	The exact code block you mean	Open <code>.ps1</code> or highlight a Terraform <code>resource</code> block
4	Open tabs	Nearby modules and schemas	<code>terraform.tfvars</code> , module, and README all open
5	Conversation history	The earlier constraints you already said out loud	'Earlier I said this must stay idempotent'
6	External tools / MCP	Live state instead of guesses	Azure inventory, Terraform state, resource graph

Before you prompt, ask one question: **what context can I add before the model starts guessing?**

Vague → specific

VAGUE

Create Terraform for a storage account

The model now has to guess provider, state, naming, tags, outputs, and security settings.

SPECIFIC

Create Terraform (HCL) for Azure Storage with: - resource group `rg-dnv-prod-ne-data` - storage account name `stdnvprdnedata01` - provider `hashicorp/azurerm` → 4.0 - module `Azure/avm-res-storage-storageaccount/azurerm` - existing `azurerm` backend from `backend.hcl`, workspace `prod` - variables from `prod.norwayeast.tfvars` - naming from `locals.naming` and required tags `environment`, `owner`, `cost_center`, `data_classification` - security baseline: TLS 1.2, public network access off, blob public access off, versioning on - output storage account ID and primary blob endpoint

Point: Every explicit constraint removes one place the model can drift.

Try it yourself — rewrite the prompt

> Write a script to clean up old files

Your job

Rewrite it so the model can stop guessing. Post your rewrite in Teams chat.

Use synthetic or public examples only — no customer data and no **internal company data outside approved governance**.

Include at least 4 of these

File type · age threshold · folder · move vs delete · dry-run / ☐ **WhatIf** · log output · return count

Time box

4 minutes writing

Then we pull 2–3 examples from chat.

What success looks like

A prompt another engineer could run without needing a follow-up interview.

Debrief — what worked

1 · Specificity

Clear file types, age limits, and paths beat generic cleanup language every time.

2 · Structure

Numbered requirements and short checklists make assumptions visible before code exists.

3 · Safety

`-WhatIf` , move instead of delete, and logging tell the model what 'safe' means here.

FALLBACK EXAMPLES IF CHAT IS SLOW

```
Scan C:\Logs for .log files older than 30 days. Move them to
C:\Archive\Logs. Add a -WhatIf switch. Write each action to
cleanup-log.txt. Return the number of files moved.
```

Different wording is fine. Clear constraints are the win.

Plan first, then code

TOOL	HOW TO INVOKE IT	WHAT TO LOOK FOR
Claude Code	Shift+Tab or /plan	Did it choose the right approach before it writes anything?
Copilot Chat	Plan first, then code: outline your approach before writing any code	Which assumptions can you approve or redirect up front?
VS Code agent mode	Toggle Plan Mode in the chat input	Can you review the path before autonomous execution?

Mental model: plan mode is code review *before* the code exists.

M5 · context is king

Resolution

“ If you fully specified it, you would have used keywords in a programming language — and you would control the thing yourself. ”

Mark Russinovich · on Hanselminutes / Scott & Mark Learn To ... Have Taste

M5 · context is king

What comes next

That's context for a single prompt.

Next: what changes when context feeds itself — from **files**, **tools**, and **memory** — so you are not manually restating everything every time?

M7 is where assistant becomes agent.

Over to Haflidi.